The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Saudi Aramco, an oil giant owned by the Saudi state, reported profits of $121bn in 2023, down from $161bn in 2022. Lower oil prices partly explain the fall. Even so, the profits were the firm's second-highest ever. The company said that last year it raised its dividends, a crucial source of income for the Saudi government, by 30% to $97.8bn.

Leo Varadkar, Ireland's prime minister, acknowledged defeat in a two-part **referendum** about modernising the constitution. His government had sought to expand the constitutional definition of families to include "durable relationships". And it wanted to change a reference to a mother's "duties in the home" to one about family-based care. Around 70% of voters rejected each proposal. Turnout was just over 44%.

President Joe Biden accused **Binyamin Netanyahu**, his Israeli counterpart, of "hurting Israel" with the mounting death toll in **Gaza**. But Mr Biden also reiterated that the "defence of Israel is still critical". Meanwhile, America's army dispatched a ship to Gaza carrying equipment to build a temporary pier off the enclave's coast. The pier would receive much-needed aid shipments but could take up to 60 days to build.

Asif Ali Zardari was voted president of Pakistan by the country's parliamentarians. He was supported by the Pakistan Peoples Party and the Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz, two parties that formed a coalition government after last month's controversial general election. Mr Zardari's term, which begins on Sunday, will be his second. His first, from 2008 to 2013, took place in the aftermath of

the assassination of his wife, Benazir Bhutto, Pakistan's first female prime minister.

Cabin crew of **Lufthansa**, Germany's biggest airline, called a two-day strike for better pay. The action is scheduled to take place on Tuesday and Wednesday. Staff believe they should benefit more from the firm's recent bumper results. It earned record profits of €1.7bn ($1.8bn) in 2023. The strike, which follows one by ground staff last week, could affect 100,000 travellers.

Joe Biden signed a $460bn package of spending bills into law just in time to prevent a partial **government shutdown**. The six bills, which were passed by the Senate on Friday, fund various government departments, including housing and transport, until the end of September. The work is not yet done, though. The deadline for passing six more such bills, which include funding for defence, is March 22nd.

America and its allies claimed to have shot down 28 drones launched by the **Houthis**, a rebel group that controls a large swathe of Yemen, against shipping in the Red Sea. The attack is one of the largest yet launched by the group since it began menacing merchant shipping in November. America and its allies have been patrolling the waterways to deter attacks on commercial shipping. But on Wednesday three people were killed in a Houthi attack on a Liberian-registered vessel.

Word of the week: Hindutva, a belief in the hegemony of Hinduism in India, which originated in the anti-colonial movements of the 20th century. Read the full story.

In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox.

Photo: Getty Images

China’s inflation mirage

China’s “monetary-policy toolbox is still rich”, said Pan Gongsheng, the governor of China’s central bank, at a press conference this week. That is the sort of thing you say when people suspect the opposite. Consumer prices in China fell year-on-year for four months in a row from October to January. To fight deflation, central banks typically cut interest rates sharply. But Mr Pan’s room for manoeuvre is limited because he does not want to overly weaken China’s currency or squeeze the profits of China’s banks.

Figures released on Saturday showed inflation turning positive in February: consumer prices rose by 0.7% compared with a year earlier. But Mr Pan cannot take too much comfort. The data may be distorted by the Spring Festival holiday, when people rushed home to their families to celebrate a new lunar year. The price of recreational travel, for example, rose by 23.1% year-on-year. When this holiday effect dissipates, Mr Pan may have to rummage through his rich toolbox again.

Photo: Getty Images

The rise of Asian concert diplomacy

As Taylor Swift ends the Asian leg of her Eras tour in Singapore on Saturday, she leaves a trail of grumbling politicians in her wake. After wondering why Ms Swift had not announced any dates in Thailand, Srettha Thavisin, the country's prime minister, said he discovered an exclusivity deal between the superstar and Singapore's government. Swifties across South-East Asia were outraged. One lawmaker from the Philippines, arguably home to the region's largest fanbase, chided Singapore's unneighbourly behaviour.

Notwithstanding the bad blood, the city-state is advantageous for stars like Ms Swift. It has excellent infrastructure, political stability and strong rule of law. The Brazil leg of the Eras tour in November, by contrast, was marred by two deaths, reports of muggings, a stampede and excessive heat. Yet leaders are eager for the billions in economic value that Ms Swift's concerts reportedly generate. With Thailand pledging to court A-list performers with their own special deals, and calls for Hong Kong to do the same, competition for Asian concert supremacy will only ramp up.

Photo: AP

Baseball against the odds in Cuba

Cuba's national baseball competition starts its 63rd season on Saturday. That the 75-game, 16-team series is going ahead at all is testimony to the sport's popularity among the island's 11.2m people and the big diaspora in the United States. In February the Cuban authorities announced a ban on all sporting events, citing fuel shortages that would prevent players and fans from travelling. An exception appears to have been quietly made for the tournament.

The fuel scarcity is part of a severe economic crisis that stems from years of mismanagement under Communist rule. Local industry is sputtering and the government lacks the foreign reserves to import goods from abroad; there is even a shortage of bread. These dire conditions will cast a shadow over the contest: the authorities have told areas hosting the series to look for sponsors to cover the costs of basic equipment including balls and bats. Still, baseball-mad Cubans will welcome any light relief.

Photo: Alex Lockett

Jack Antonoff’s own sound

Jack Antonoff is one of contemporary music’s biggest hitmakers. He has written or co-written songs with Lana del Rey, Lorde and Troye Sivan; he has produced albums by Diana Ross and St Vincent. In recent years he has become Taylor Swift’s go-to collaborator; she has described him as “so talented it’s incomprehensible”. His work on her blockbuster albums “Folklore”, “Evermore” and “Midnights” helped him win the Grammy for Producer of the Year (Non-Classical) in 2022, 2023 and 2024—making him only the second person to win the prize in three consecutive years.

This weekend Mr Antonoff released “Bleachers”, by his rock band of the same name. The record shows off the “Antonoff Sound”, with its trademark grandiose choruses and bridges, as well as 1980s-style synth and punchy guitars. The record contains some catchy tunes (“Tiny Moves”) and throwbacks (“Modern Girl”), but never quite recreates the magic of Mr Antonoff’s work with other artists. Call it musical altruism.

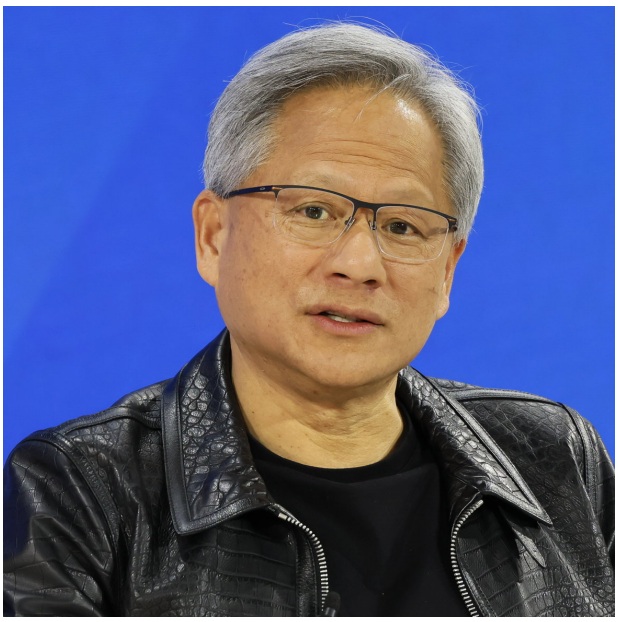


Photo: Getty Images

Jensen Huang, shovel-maker for the AI gold rush

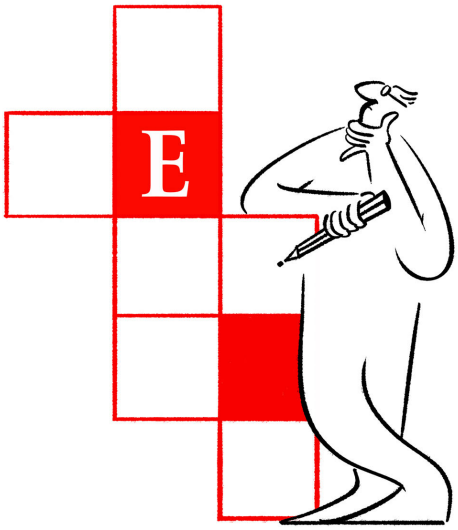
Jensen Huang is a paranoid man. The boss of Nvidia, an American chip designer, is fond of saying that his company is always “30 days away from going out of business”. Recent developments, however, are making a mockery of such talk. Thanks to an artificial-intelligence (AI) boom, Nvidia is now America’s third-most valuable firm. Its market capitalisation of $2.2trn is only exceeded by Microsoft and Apple.

Mr Huang’s paranoia can be traced back to his roots. After his family moved from Taiwan to America he was sent to a Baptist school for troubled youths. There, he shared a room with a knife-scarred boy. That did little to distract him from academic success: he sped through high school, graduating at 16. In 1993, aged 30 and armed with two degrees in electrical engineering, he founded Nvidia with two other engineers. The start-up had to compete in a cut-throat semiconductor market dominated by heavyweights like Intel, then the world’s biggest chipmaker.

Beyond paranoia, two further traits explain how Mr Huang has propelled Nvidia to success. The first is a focus on the long term.

He realised early on that simply making fast chips was not enough: customers also needed help in tailoring them for their specific needs. In the mid 2000s he started investing in “CUDA”, a software platform that enables Nvidia’s customers to make the most of its chips. Many saw software development as a costly distraction for a chip company. But today CUDA is one of the company’s strongest defences against competitors.

The second is Mr Huang’s propensity for bold bets. Almost a decade ago he realised that Nvidia’s graphics-processor units, which were originally built for video-game consoles, also worked well for training AI models. Mr Huang shifted his company’s resources towards building chips for AI applications, long before the current boom in large language models. In 2017 he surprised investors by saying that the company’s transition to AI could “work out great, or terribly” since the firm was “all in”. Even for Mr Huang, great would be an understatement.



Weekly crossword

Our crossword has two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give

the same answers, all of which feature in articles in this week's edition of *The Economist*:

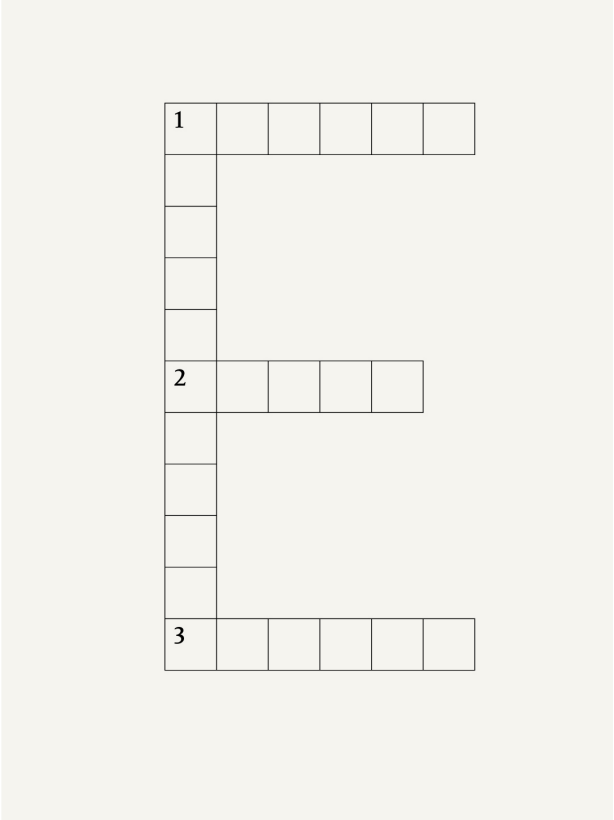
Cryptic clues

1 *down* Contraceptives press for formal approval (6,5)
1 *across* Anger a twisted old leader (6)
2 *across* Where roads come from, so we are told (5)
3 *across* Swap an amazing selection of headwear (6)

Factual clues

1 *down* Common description of China's parliament (6,5)
1 *across* American president who blocked arms sales to Israel (6)
2 *across* What Brothers of Italy has in post-fascist movements (5)
3 *across* Country where the president has been investigated for corruption (6)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners in next week's edition.



The winners of this week’s quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week’s quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Victor Arotsky, London, Britain
Josh Perrott, Toronto, Canada

Alexandra Balan, Bucharest, Romania

They all gave the correct answers of *Shake Shack*, *the blank tile*, *extract blood*, *cardigan* and *Love Story.* The theme is hits by Taylor Swift: *Shake It Off*, *Blank Space*, *Bad Blood*, *Cardigan* and *Love Story*.

The questions were:

Monday: Which burger chain was founded in New York in 2004 by Danny Meyer?
Tuesday: Which is the only tile in Scrabble that scores zero points?
Wednesday: What role does a phlebotomist play in medicine?
Thursday: What is the term for a knitted jumper that buttons up?
Friday: Which 1970 movie saw Ryan O'Neal romance Ali McGraw?

The vote is a power, a weapon of offence and defence, a prayer.

Carrie Chapman Catt